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FEATURES

How love for food made me participate in HackaNoodle?

Shakti Prasad SS · Grofers / Blinkit Lambda

Nihal and his friends at HackaNoodle 2022

What do you say when someone asks you why are you participating in a Hackathon? Saying that you've come to a hackathon for (free) food is not the ideal response, and more so to a CEO.

It was a Saturday morning, and I was in the Blinkit headquarters for a hackathon. Our team was working in one of the many glass meeting rooms when a serious-looking man in a black hoodie walked in and introduced himself, saying, "Hi, I'm Deepi".

Hearing this, one of my teammates said, "I got it". I, on the other hand, was super confused. I thought, maybe, I heard 'DP', which is an acronym for 'delivery partner' at Blinkit. I thought it was an internal joke I was unaware of. So, I just smiled and let it pass.

We began talking about the project, and after sharing and receiving a few suggestions, the man in black asked, "Yahan kya karne aaye ho?", which loosely translates to "what are you doing here?" I mentioned the first (honest) thing that came to my mind, "khaana khaane", translating to "to have food". And, we all had a hearty laugh.

Shortly after he left, my teammate, who was smiling earlier, nudged me and said it was the founder you were speaking with. It took me a good ten minutes to let that sink in.

Well, this is one of the many unusual things that happened last weekend at the headquarters. Let's start from the beginning.

A few weeks back, I was browsing through my LinkedIn feed and came across a post on HackaNoodle — a hackathon powered by Blinkit, with a special focus on women and the trans community. A big fan of hackathons/coding competitions in general, I quickly opened the link to learn more about it and, soon after, registered my name.

Since HackaNoodle was scheduled for November, we all had a few days to form our teams. We made a team of four — Ritika Patel, Palak Bansal, Akshit Sehgal, and me (Nihal Gupta). We started meeting online on Zoom calls to brainstorm what we wanted to build. With Diwali and festive preparations, the days went by quickly. Finally, the much-awaited weekend was here.

The D-day

On November 5th, we all were standing outside a large building in Gurugram with a huge, yellow board on top reading Blinkit. It did not feel like anything big until we stepped in. But oh, how it all changed as soon as I entered the office. I could feel the energy all around me — hundreds of coders, a lot of hustle, and the crew welcoming each of us. However, one thing that (pleasantly) surprised me was

the number of women present there. We had 40+ teams, and all of them were led by women.

At the gates, we all got our goodie bags. Like a child, I took my bag aside, found the nearest table, sat there and started unpacking everything one by one. There was a cool black hoodie with my name written on it (which I wore then and there), a laptop pad, a water bottle, stickers (special thanks to the person who included cool stickers in the goodie bag, I love pasting stickers on my laptop), and a few munchies.

Once everyone settled in, the engineering team started briefing us on HackaNoodle — what it was, the theme, the judging criteria, and more. Here, we got to know how Zomato was founded because of a pizza craving Deepinder Goyal had 14 years back (now that I recall this, my answer does not sound dumb — food can take you places!). The story made us realise that we seldom remember how everything starts with a basic idea — be it a product or an organisation.

And we had 24 hours to think of that idea and build it from scratch.

And it began...

The marathon started, and all teams got a room each to eat, sleep, code, and repeat!

We hurried to discuss what we should build. Since the theme was "Build India's Next Unicorn", we had many horizons to explore. The challenge was to pick out the best.

In between our brainstorming sessions, the Blinkit team came for check-ins. They mentored and brainstormed with us and gave us real-time suggestions. It felt great to work with such brilliant minds.

Code, code, and more code

Once we finalised the idea, the rest of the day was packed with coding, caffeine, fixing bugs, and, yes... more caffeine.

We continuously tested our code, scratched our heads, and pulled our hair out when the code was not working. But in the end — we made it work!

Food scenes

What kept us working all those long hours without snapping at each other was food. We were in Blinkit's office, so no doubt the food arrangements had to be grand! Everything we needed — unlimited beverages, noodles, and munchies — was within an arm's distance. A great variety of dishes were served during every meal.

It felt like I was Charlie, and this was my chocolate factory.

The showtime

The next morning, we had to showcase what we had built. On one side were the top leaders of Zomato and Blinkit, and

MINI Countryman Gets Adventure Packages, All-Terrain Tires for 2026

Steven Paul · BMW Blog

It wasn't too long ago that MINI offered just one car. The Cooper is still the brand's most iconic offering, but the Countryman SUV arguably presents a more practical solution. This week, the brand introduced new port-installed options that make the not-quite-a-truck even more versatile. From all-terrain tires to roof racks and everything in between, MINI's offering a veritable wealth of customization on the new Countryman ALL4.

Breaking Down MINI Countryman Port-Installed Options

Arguably the biggest news here is MINI's addition of two 'option packages.' The first is the MINI Adventure Package, option code OZ01, which bundles accessories that make the Countryman a bit more durable overall. It includes a roof rack base, all-weather floor mats, paint protection film, luggage mat, and loading sill protection mat. At \$1,100, it's probably a fairly good value for the paint protection film alone. However, the MINI Countryman gets its true off-road bona fides at the next level: the MINI Adventure Plus Package.

MINI Countryman Adventure Package

The MINI Adventure Plus Package sets you back quite a bit more: \$3,555. It also only adds one thing: new wheels and tires. Dig the new shoes: JCW Y-Spoke wheels in Frozen Midnight Grey, dubbed Style 945. More importantly, the new

wheels come wrapped in all-terrain tires, General Grabber AT3s. The wheels alone cost \$2,465. So, you save exactly \$10 with the MINI Adventure Plus Package, compared to ordering the MINI Adventure Package and the wheels separately. What a deal!

Of course, MINI also offers a selection of ancillary accessories to go along with these new port-installed packages. A ski/snowboard holder, bicycle roof rack, and roof box — the latter as a dealer-installed accessory — are all available, complementing the roof rack base included in the MINI Adventure Package. MINI also offers various mats and coverings as port-installed options, like all-weather floor mats. "Our accessories are the perfect addition to the most versatile models, for the adventurer looking to equip their vehicle to enjoy maximum fun of the great outdoors, any season of the year," said Vikash Joshi, Product Manager at MINI USA.

Off-Roading Your EV? MINI Has You Covered, Apparently

For those deeply curious, yes: you can order the all-terrain tires on the electric Countryman. MINI's press release: "This wheel and tire set (OZFJ) is available on the MINI Countryman S ALL4 and MINI Countryman SE ALL4." It's the first time BMW or MINI have offered a full EV with off-road tires, which is perhaps an interesting anecdote as the rumors of a BMW M off-roader continue to crop up. Alongside it, whispers of a "BMW Rugged SUV" swirl — though less now than

Early contraceptive discontinuation and associated factors among married women initiating long-acting and short-acting contraceptives in humanitarian settings in Ethiopia: A retrospective cohort study

Juliana Yartey Enos · PLOS ONE Feed

by Andamlak Gizaw Alamdo, Agnes M. Kotoh, Emefa Judith Modey, Juliana Yartey Enos

The sexual and reproductive health (SRH) service provision in conflict-affected populations has been continually overlooked. International and local relief organizations have begun to recognize the neglect of women's SRH needs; however, SRH services and humanitarian responses remain sub-optimal. Contraceptive discontinuation is a significant public health issue with considerable impact on family planning (FP) programs, as well as on women's SRH and population growth. There is scarce information regarding the dynamics of contraceptive use in refugee areas. Evidence on contraceptive use dynamics is vital, especially now, as the global refugee crisis grows. Therefore, this study aimed to examine first-year contraceptive discontinuation and associated factors among married women initiating long-acting reversible contraceptives (LARC) and short-acting contraceptives (SAC) in selected refugee populations in Ethiopia.

A retrospective cohort study was conducted among 551 married women in selected refugee populations in Ethiopia. After reviewing FP registries, all eligible women who initiated a contraceptive method 12–18 months before data col-

lection were included in the study. Through computer-assisted face-to-face interviews, data on the socio-demographic, reproductive, and contraceptive use history of women were collected. Key characteristics of SAC acceptors and LARC acceptors were compared using chi-square statistics and t-tests. A multi-variable Cox proportional hazards model identified the predictors of time to contraceptive discontinuation during the first year of use. In addition, adjusted hazard ratios (aHR), 95% CI, and P-values were calculated to determine the magnitude and precision of the association.

The 12-month discontinuation rate for all contraceptive methods was 41.2% (95% CI: 37.2–45.4). The discontinuation rate for SAC (44.94%) was higher than LARC (32.32%) ($P \leq 0.001$). The factors associated with 12-month discontinuation include method type (aHR = 1.50; 95% CI: 1.06–2.12), residence (aHR = 1.83; 95% CI: 1.24–2.70), husband occupation (aHR = 0.49; 95% CI: 0.29–0.84), length of stay in the refugee camp (aHR = 0.95; 95% CI: 0.92–0.99), and intention to use contraceptives in the future (aHR = 0.15; 95% CI: 0.11–0.21).

A high rate of early contraceptive discontinuation was documented among refugee women, with a higher discontinuation rate among SAC acceptors. To improve contraceptive service provision and maintain continuous use of

Cheap drones allowing war with volume

Nathan Yau · *FlowingData*

Unmanned and relatively cheap drones that can be manufactured in high volume have changed airspace typically dominated by expensive jets and trained pilots. Reuters illustrates the shift that allowed less equipped countries to fight against larger ones .

In just the first week of the conflict, Iran launched more than 1,000 drones and it is estimated to have the capacity to produce around 10,000 per month.

The technology of war has evolved rapidly in recent years, a shift starkly illustrated by Ukraine's fight against Russia. What began as a conflict dominated by tanks and artillery has increasingly become a drone war. Outgunned in conventional armor and aircraft, Ukraine turned to inexpensive unmanned systems for reconnaissance and attack. Drones are estimated to account for about 70% of Russian casualties, enabling strikes to be carried out remotely and reducing the risk to pilots and aircrews.

The build-up to show scale in this piece is quite something. Expensive and specialized aircraft fly across at first. Then a switch to hundreds of drones filling the sky shows the task of defending against high volume.

Tags: cost , drones , Reuters , scale , war

Underlying structure and measurement invariance by sex of the state trait anxiety inventory: A psychometric analysis in Ecuador

Alberto Rodríguez-Lorenzana · *PLOS ONE Feed*

by Jose A. Rodas, Daniel Oleas, Guido Mascialino, José Alejandro Valdevila Figueira, Alberto Rodríguez-Lorenzana

Anxiety is currently one of the most prevalent and investigated psychological symptoms requiring precise and reliable instruments for its assessment. The current study evaluates the psychometric properties of the State-Trait Anxiety Inventory (STAI) in an Ecuadorian sample, focusing on the factor structure and potential methodological artefacts, especially those introduced by reverse-scored items. Employing exploratory and confirmatory factor analyses (EFA and CFA), along with structural equation modelling (SEM), the research examines the presence of two distinct factors: genuine anxiety and a secondary factor related to reversed items. Findings indicate that the expected two-factor model fits the data more accurately than a unidimensional model. Notably, cross-loadings suggest the second factor may represent a substantive positive, anxiety-free state rather than solely a methodological effect. Additionally, multigroup CFA confirmed strict measurement invariance across sex, supporting the scale's utility for group comparisons. These results suggest that the STAI's total score represents a composite of anxiety and well-being. While the STAI remains a robust tool for evaluating anxiety in clinical contexts, researchers seeking pure measures of anxiety symptomatology should consider analysing the subscales separately.

ANALYSIS

The X-Peditions Workshops Site has Moved!

David Hobby · Strobist

Two pieces of news, on the X-Peditions Hanoi photo workshops front:

The first is that I retired from teaching as of November 2025. But X-Peditions is still going strong.

The second piece of news is that their new instructor, as of Fall 2026, will be none other than Ibarionex Perello, of The Candid Frame podcast fame (among many other things.)

He is perhaps the best person in the world to be stepping in as my successor. And I know you're going to enjoy working with him.

Our Local producer in Hanoi is also remaining, which is also fantastic news. You could not be in better hands.

The X-Peditions Hanoi Workshops page is now located [here](#).

Deals: Take Up to \$199 Off Apple's M1 MacBook Pro and MacBook Air at Best Buy and Amazon

Mitchel Broussard · MacRumors

Best Buy and Amazon are both offering great deals on numerous models of the MacBook Pro and MacBook Air today, including a handful of record low deals on the latest Apple notebooks.

Note: MacRumors is an affiliate partner with some of these vendors. When you click a link and make a purchase, we may receive a small payment, which helps us keep the site running.

13-Inch M1 MacBook Air

Starting with the 2020 M1 13-inch MacBook Air, you'll find the 256GB notebook for \$899.00 at Amazon and \$899.99 at Best Buy, down from \$999.00. Amazon stock has dwindled and will "ship soon," but Best Buy has plenty of stock in all three colors.

Additionally, both retailers have the 512GB M1 MacBook Air at \$1,099.99, down from \$1,249.00. While this is a record low price on the 512GB notebook, the 256GB model's discount is a second-best price.

M1 MacBook Air, 256GB - \$899.99, down from \$999.00 at Best Buy / Amazon

M1 MacBook Air, 512GB - \$1,099.99, down from \$1,249.00 at Best Buy / Amazon

13-Inch M1 MacBook Pro

For the newest MacBook Pro models, Best Buy and Amazon have lowest ever prices on the new 2020 M1 13-inch MacBook Pro. You

can get the 256GB notebook for \$1,099.99, down from \$1,299.00, in both Silver and Space Gray.

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New Scientist Space, New Scientist Space: Black holes don't just bend space and time. They also expose where our understanding of reality begins to break. In this video, we explore supermassives, wormholes, gravastars and much more

Jesse Steinmetz, Live Science: A very long solar filament that had been snaking around the sun erupted with a flourish on Dec. 6, 2010.

John J. Wiens **Ellerie G. Blomenkamp** **Miles Corliss** **Xin Lia** **Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology, University of Arizona, Tucson, AZ 85721-0088** **Institute of Applied Biology, Shanxi Key Laboratory of Nucleic Acid Biopesticides, School of Life Sciences, Shanxi University, Taiyuan 030006, Shanxi, China, PNAS News:** Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, Volume 123, Issue 12, March 2026. Significance The diversity of living organisms is increasingly threatened by human impacts, but still poorly known. Recently, there has been growing interest in protecting species that are especially divergent, including distinct genera and families (i.e., ...

Harry Baker, Live Science: Russia's Progress spacecraft have been used to ferry cargo to the ISS throughout the entirety of the space station's history. This photo shows Progress 45 docking with the ISS in 2011.

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Edward P. Snelling, Nature News: Nature, Published online: 25 March 2026; doi:10.1038/s41586-026-10291-3

New evidence suggests that diffusive oxygen transport through the tracheolar-muscle system is not the limiting factor on insect body size.

Tory Shepherd, The Guardian Science/Space: Study into how fertilisation could work in space finds sperm may get disorientated when trying to find an egg

Sperm in space are likely to get disoriented and lost while struggling to find their way to an egg, a new study has found.

When exposed to microgravity in experiments, sperm tumble around like an untethered astronaut, according to Adelaide University researchers.

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Hoyt Patrick Taylor IV, Nature News: Nature, Published online: 25 March 2026; doi:10.1038/s41586-026-10219-x

fMRI data from individuals of a wide range of ages (from a few days to 100 years old) are used to map the key organizational axes of functional connectivity in the human cortex throughout the lifespan.

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New Scientist Space, New Scientist Space: Spacecraft orbiting the Red Planet have helped researchers map out an ancient coastline that surrounded a large ocean billions of years ago

*A tuner could work with the car, not against it, adjusting its character in ways
that felt tangible and immediate.*

Josh Ryner

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